old parachutes. For years we had been wasting energy and resources on collecting used parachutes from forward posts.'

The land route to Dhola perforce had to be over the circuitous trails that connected Lumpu to the Nam Ka Chu, for the obvious route along the Nyamjang Chu was under the nose of the Chinese positions on Thagla. Due to sheer cliffs around the confluence of the west-east flowing Nam Ka Chu and the north-south Nyamjang Chu, it was difficult to approach Dhola from Khenzemane. Even the central route over Hathung-la that connected Bridge 1 to Lumpu was under Chinese observation and troops could come under artillery fire while negotiating the steep slopes. Hence, it was felt that the main approach would have to be the track that ran from Lumpu to Bridge 2 via Karpo-la 1.

Dalvi later described the difficult conditions along the route. The occasional huts they came across were the only shelter and could house but a few men. Carrying heavy loads, they were climbing at a height of over 10,000 feet. The descent was very dangerous and a false step meant a broken ankle. Dalvi says he 'reached Bridge 1 exhausted and mentally depressed'. While the route looks a short hop on a map, on the ground it was arduous. 'The turn-around time for loaded men, from Lumpu to Nam Ka Chu Valley was a minimum of 4 days.'

AN EAR TO THE GROUND

Ever since 8 September, when news had reached Army HQ that the Dhola post had reported 600 armed Chinese approaching it, confusion had reigned. Lieutenant General Kaul, the CGS, was away on a holiday in Kashmir, and the DMO, Brigadier Palit, was also away on a naval cruise. The deputy CGS was Major General Joginder 'Jogi' Singh Dhillon, swho at the time was officiating for Kaul. As per established norms and procedures, all decisions should have been routed through the Directorate of Military Operations who through the CGS would have advised the COAS on the matter.

Instead, the defence minister, Krishna Menon, called a conference on 12 September to discuss the Dhola incident, to which he invited, along with General Pran Thapar, the Eastern Army Commander, General Bogey Sen. Though there were no records kept of the meeting, it is now fairly obvious that the decision to mount an attack on the Thagla Ridge to clear out the